Half-Hanged Catra MacNaghten

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Teen And Up Audiences

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

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Half-Hanged Catra MacNaghten

by DeltaFell

Summary

Catra had long been a drunkard and a gambler. But she was trying to get their claws out from her brain. It was, well, it was tough, but she'd been making progress. And she ran into Adora again, and finally, she had a reason to crawl out of the bottle and to stay out. They started courting, and it was looking good. Catra really should've known that nothing could be that good for very long. Not for her.

"No. Adora, no, don't give up. Stay with me please," Catra begged.

Adora winced and sat herself up off the ground slightly. Her already red clothes were soaked with a deeper scarlet all across her chest.

Notes

Hey y'all, content warnings for alcohol abuse and mentions of a gambling addiction, as well as for MCD, suicidal ideation ,and an attempt.

See the end of the work for more notes

"Let her marry you? I'd rather see Adora dead than in your company , Catra," Shadow W eaver spat. "A drunkard and a gambler too? No, I have a just and fair man for my Adora."

Catra stood in the rain outside the Weaver estate. The old manor was showing its age, vines crawling up the side of the building, and cracks splitting the facade. She hadn't wanted to press the issue yet, but Adora had insisted. She just couldn't bear to keep them a secret from her dear mother. Some mother she was.

"B t, mother , I love Catra," Adora said.

"Nonsense! Y ou cannot possibly love this mongrel and vagrant, she must have confused and corrupted you. She is but a distraction from what your duty must be," Shadow W eaver said.

"Mother , I do not want to join the government. That has always been your wish, not mine. Let me go and be with Catra!" Adora protested.

"No. I will have no daughter of mine in her company . Now come, Adora, there is work to be done," Shadow W eaver said, pulling Adora back from the doorway. Adora fought viciously, but it was hopeless. Catra could see that even from outside the manor.

"J st go, Adora, I'll be fine. G be happy , okay? I'll figure something out," Catra said.

Catra looked away so she wouldnt have to see Adora' s expression as Shadow Weaver shut the door. She turned away from the manor and into the rain. What could she do, when up against the long arm of Shadow Weaver?

Catra found herself in the bar again. After all her hard work, after months of staying away, she'd once again come back to crawl back in the bottle when the slightest thing went wrong. Catra drank deep and long. She hated it, she hated herself for needing it, but she found she couldnt stop herself. They had been so close to happiness, to getting out from this shitty town, and it all just had to go to shit. Just like it always had for her . Just like it always would.

"Hey , Catra, are you okay?" asked a voice from behind her . It was Scorpia, one of her oldest friends, and the person who'd been helping her try to beat her addiction.

"What do you think," Catra snapped bitterly .

"Hey , hey, now. Remember what we've been working on. Dont snap at someone unless they deserve it. And last Iwas aware, Ihadnt done anything to deserve being snapped at. Are you okay Catra?

Catra felt the familiar twist of shame in her gut. She was backsliding again, and she'd drive everyone around her away. Just like she had the last time, except this time there would be no one there to help her stand back up again.

"No. Adora told Shadow Weaver about us, seeking to gain her permission to marry me, and it went to hell from there. I knew that bitch would never accept it. Would never accept us. I told her, Scorp, I tried to warn her away from going to Shadow Weaver until we could run away together. It would just have been one more year until Adora would've been old enough. One more year. And here I am, chasing comfort at the bottom of the barrel again."

"It takes a lot of work to beat an addiction, Catra. The road is hard, and it is long. You are going to fall, and fall again on that path. What matters is that each time you fall, each time you fail at your goal, you get back up again," Scorpia said.

"But what does it matter?" moaned Catra, "We'll never get to be together. Why should I seek the road out when there is nothing at the end but more sadness and pain?"

Scorpia smiled, soft and warm, even from across the table. "I think I might know someone who can help with that," she said.

Catra found herself sitting on the back of a large horse, not three weeks later. Scorpia, as it turned out, knew a local highwayman who fancied herself more of a resistance fighter. One with plenty of reasons to spite Shadow Weaver. So Scorpia arranged for the three of them, plus Entrapta, to meet and told them her plan.

She knew Shadow Weaver would be taking Adora on a retreat this weekend, having heard it from a waitress who heard it from a friend who heard it from the groundskeeper, and so-on and so forth. So, Scorpia planned for them to disguise themselves as members of Perfuma's gang, rob the stagecoach, and simultaneously rescue Adora from her evil mother's clutches.

t was audacious, but it just might work. Catra certainly hoped it would, otherwise they'd all be headed for the gallows. She didnt have anything to lose, but her friends both did. She hoped they were certain about this plan.

Before Catra could ruminate further , and think again about going through with this insane plan, she heard the rumbling of several carriages on the road.

"Okay folks, that' s our carriage!" Perfuma shouted down, climbing out of a tree and onto the horse she and Scorpia shared.

The highwaymen around Catra all spurred their horses into action and towards the road. Following their lead, Catra did as well, drawing her pistol from its holster. She was nervous, terrified, really,

but the nerves inside her had stilled. It was all or nothing now . Either she and Adora would escape, or she'd be hanged.

Perfuma shouted out to the first carriage. "You've been surrounded. This is the Plumeria Gang, so if you comply with our directions everyone can go home safe and sound."

The door opened, and out stepped someone wearing red, with what looked to Catra to be long black hair. She involuntarily squeezed her finger at the sight of Shadow Weaver. Her pistol, which had been trained on the figure, fired, and the bullet struck the figure, dropping them.

As the figure fell, they cried out, and Catra realized it had not been Shadow Weaver she just shot, but Adora, dressed as her despicable mother.

Catra leaped from her horse, running over to Adora. "No, no, no, Adora, why?" she screamed, anguished.

Catra's hands searched Adora's body, looking for where the bullet wound was.

"Why do you have to be the one with the martyr complex? Why , Adora? Doesn't it matter what you want too?" she asked.

Adora coughed. "Hey , Catra. Fancy seeing you here."

Behind and all around Catra she heard sounds of fighting. Something was wrong, this carriage train was only supposed to have house staff, not armed guards, but it didn't matter to Catra. Nothing mattered but Adora.

"What were you doing, going out dressed like your mother? You know she has enemies, and what they'd do," Catra said.

"I hoped," Adora winced in pain, "I had hoped to earn her favor , so she would let us marry and I could be with you again."

"Oh Adora, you self-sacrificing idiot," Catra sobbed.

"Hey , hey, I'm here now . Don't waste what time we have," Adora said.

"No. Adora, no, don't give up. Stay with me please," Catra begged.

Adora winced and sat herself up off the ground slightly. Her already red clothes were soaked with a deeper scarlet all across her chest.

"I don't have long, Catra. That's the way things are, it seems. Let us cherish the little time we have left together," Adora said faintly.

Catra looked away from her search to look Adora in the face. Adora's face was pale now, almost grey.

"I can't lose you, Adora. I don't know what I'll do once you're gone," she said.

Adora smiled weakly, "You'll figure it out, I'm sure. You've always been so smart. Smarter than I ever was. You've always meant the world to me, Catra, and I hope you understood that long before now. I'm sorry, Catra, I-" Adora's eyes fluttered and shut closed.

Catra gripped Adora tight and sobbed, raw and hurting. She stayed this way for what felt like hours, unable to move, unable to even think. She didn't notice when rough arms pulled her away from Adora.

Catra woke up in a cell. She'd been confined there for some time, ever since Adora's death. There had been attempts to get her out, but she just stayed in her cell, listless. Shadow Weaver was right. She deserved to be here. She deserved what Catra knew was coming to her.

There was a jingle of keys as the warden walked past. It was nearly noon. That meant another prisoner from here would be sent out to be executed, again. Catra had lost track of the days, but all the cells to her right were empty. She knew what that meant.

"C'mon you. It's your lucky day," The warden's gruff voice rumbled.

Catra stood limply, arms and head dangling. The warden bound her hands and feet before shoving her out of her cell.

"Hey," it was the prisoner in the cell to the left of her. A woman with short pink hair and a face tattoo, she had been there when Catra was brought in.

"Good luck," the woman said.

The warden shoved Catra along and out into the daylight before she could respond. Her throat was too choked up to respond anyways. The light outside the jail was blinding, forcing Catra to cover her face with her bound hands as she stepped out.

She blinked, and she could see the wooden gallows and the crowd gathered around them. Great. There were people here who wanted to see her dead. Understandable, really, because she wished the same.

Catra felt numb as she was walked up the gallows, as she had these past days? Months? It was hard to tell how long it had been since she shot Adora. Since she had murdered her. Catra didn't look at the soldiers surrounding the gallows

Catra felt the noose as it was tightened around her neck, and she looked off the platform into the crowd below. They didn't look happy, as she had expected. They looked angry. She saw a few familiar faces amongst the crowd. Scorpia, Entrapta, Perfuma and her gang. Of course, they were here to see that she got exactly what she deserved. For a second, Catra thought she saw Adora amongst the crowd, but she blinked, and that person vanished. She knew it was impossible anyways. Adora was dead, she had killed her.

The hangman stepped back from her, reading her charges as he prepared to pull the lever that would drop her to her death. Well, if she couldn't have anything else in her life, at least she could have her death.

While the hangman was still reading her charges, Catra leaped off the platform of the gallows, intending to beat him to the punch with her own death. And she fell, but rather than the sudden snap of her neck she expected, the rope broke, and she continued falling into the crowd.

At the same time, nine shots rang out into the sky. Catra looked behind her, confused, and saw that all the soldiers on the gallows were dead. She turned around and saw Adora reaching out one hand, the other wrapped in a sling.

"C'mon Catra, let's go," said Adora.

Catra blinked, and took her hand. It was real. She was really here. She reached up and grabbed Adora tightly with a hug.

"I missed you, dummy. How'd you even get here?" Catra said.

"You have some very good friends," Adora smiled.

The crowd, which had fallen silent when she jumped, parted for the two of them like a wave against rocks.

"Shall we?" asked Adora.

Catra grinned and grasped her good hand as they walked out of the crowd, and off into the sunset.

End Notes

So, uh this fic was inspired by the song Half-Hanged MacNaghten, which is based on the legend of John MacNaghten, a real person from the 1700s. MacNaghten wasn't exactly the greatest of people (his Adora was 15, and he was at least 38, so yike) however, the story of his fight and death became romanticized as a symbol of resistance and grief, which inspired the song which lead to me listening to it and getting an idea. This one has been kicking around for a few months, it just took me a while to get to writing it.

So, turns out I can't predict my own schedule any better than the weathermen predict the weather (go figure). I have not left either Arcane or SPOP behind, I'll most certainly keep writing both, with some TLT mixed in to spice things up. I dunno when I'll post next (probably next friday), but I've been re-reading Dresden Files this week, so expect something urban fantasy when I do. I am back where I was when I wrote Night Running, so I would not be surprised if that sees an update in the next two months.

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!